

Board 1

North Deals
None Vul

♠ K J 9 6
♥ J 10 5 4
♦ 10 6
♣ 10 8 5

♠ 8 7 5 2
♥ A K
♦ A J 3
♣ A 6 4 2



♠ Q
♥ Q 9 8 6 2
♦ 9 5
♣ K Q J 9 3

♠ A 10 4 3
♥ 7 3
♦ K Q 8 7 4 2
♣ 7

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			
4♠ by North			

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Well, he has 4 ♠s. That's why you used Stayman so you bid 4♠.

The contract would be 4♠ played by South.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♣K. Seeing 10 top tricks sort of makes you wish you had just bid 3NT.

Loser List: ♠ = 2/3/4 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 ::
Total = 2/3/4

Missing 5 ♠s, the most likely split is 3-2, (68% of the time). You win the ♣A and play a small ♠ toward dummy. East puts on the ♠Q which you take with dummy's ♠A, West following with the ♠6.

Do you play ♠s again? or not?

Not. With both defenders following suit, the possibility of 4 ♠ losers is gone so you can lose at most 3. But that ♠Q from East is ominous. If you play another ♠ and they do split 3-2 you will make 11 tricks, losing only 2 trumps. But if West has 3 ♠s left he will win the trick, pull all the rest of the trumps, and lead a ♣ to East.

The guaranteed way to make the contract is to play no more ♠s, but to start playing ♦ winners. The defenders can make their 3 trump tricks but you maintain control of the hand.

As you see, playing a second trump would have been disastrous.

But with a different distribution, (3-2), playing the second trump would have been great.

Considering probabilities it looks like this. If you play the second trump you will make 2 overtricks about 70% of the time, but you will go down 4 about 30% of the time.

If you stop with the ♠s and start running ♦s you will make your contract 100% of the time but will never make an overtrick.

Board 3
West Deals
E-W Vul

♠ Q J 3
♥ A 5
♦ A K 8 2
♣ Q 8 3 2

♠ 9 7 4
♥ J 9 7 2
♦ Q 10
♣ A K 6 5

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 10 6 2
♥ K Q 10 8 6 3
♦ 5
♣ 7 4

♠ A 8 5
♥ 4
♦ J 9 7 6 4 3
♣ J 10 9

West	North	East	South
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♦	Pass	4♥	
All Pass			

4♥ by East
♣9 which you ruff.

Yes, you have a 6-card ♥ suit. But you also have 4 ♠s, so you start with a Stayman 2♣.

Partner says 2♦;

Yes, you have a 6-card ♥ suit. But you also have 4 ♠s, so you start with a Stayman 2♣.

Partner says 2♦;

OK, no 4-4 ♠ fit. But partner has at least 2♥ so you know you have an 8-card (or better) fit there. With 10 points you have to decide whether to invite or insist, and you like the looks of this hand so you bid 4♥.

East plays 4♥. South leads the ♣J. You play low from dummy and South continues with ♣10, then

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = ? : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 3 + ?

You don't expect a trump loser, and obviously you cannot afford to have one.

So after ruffing the third ♣ you play ♥A, then ♥Q. Aargh! South discards a ♦ on the second trump.

North has left the ♥ J 9 while you have the ♥ Q 10 8. If only dummy had another ♥ you could finesse North's ♥J, but, alas, dummy has none. Can you see another way to accomplish the finesse?

If you could manage to be in dummy after trick 11, and have nothing in your hand but the ♥ Q 10, while North had nothing in his hand but the ♥ J 9 you would have him. But to accomplish this you must use up your ♥8 beforehand.

You enter dummy with a ♦, then play a small ♦ and ruff with your ♥8. Then play your ♠K. South wins this and assume he plays another ♠.

Win the ♠ in dummy, then play ♦K, and the other ♠ winner. If North has to follow to all these then you will have accomplished your objective; North will be down to ♥ J 9 and will have to ruff trick 12 with one of them - which you will over-ruff.

One possibility was not mentioned earlier.

When you played a third ♦ to ruff with your ♥8, North **COULD** have ruffed this. If he had, it would have handed you your contract since you could over-ruff and take care of your trump problem immediately.

By the way, ruffing a card to purposely shorten your trump holding is called a Trump Coup.